



What you inherited without knowing

Invisible loyalties: why you repeat what you swore you'd never repeat.

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This ebook is a self-knowledge and understanding resource. It does not replace therapeutic support or family constellation sessions. If you feel that the patterns you recognize cause you persistent suffering, please seek professional help. Seeing is the first step. Taking care of yourself is the second.

1. "I'll never be like my mother."

It's half past seven in the evening. Dinner still isn't ready, the laundry has been forgotten in the machine since yesterday, and the youngest is crying because her brother took her toy. You're tired. Not the normal kind of tired, the kind a coffee fixes. It's the tiredness that settles into your bones, that has followed you since this morning, since last week, since you can no longer remember when it began.

And then it happens.

The oldest answers you in a way that makes you lose your patience. Maybe it was the tone. Maybe it was the look. Maybe it was simply the last drop. You open your mouth and a sentence comes out. Not just any sentence. *That* sentence. With *that* tone. With *that* exact intonation you would recognize anywhere in the world, because you heard it hundreds of times.

It is your mother's voice.

Not similar. Identical. The same words, the same harshness, the same look that made you feel small when you were seven years old. And now you are the one saying them. And your child looks at you the same way

you used to look at your mother: with fear, with confusion, with something breaking inside without making a sound.

You freeze. You stop mid-sentence. And inside you, a quiet voice says what you have already said a thousand times: "I swore I would never be like this."

If this scene feels familiar, in one way or another, I want you to know something before we go any further: you are not weak. You have not failed. And you are not alone in this. Practically every woman I know, and many I work with, has lived through some version of this moment. The moment when the promise breaks. The moment when you realize you are doing the very thing you fought against your whole life.

"I'll never be like my mother." It is perhaps the most spoken, most felt, and most betrayed sentence in the history of women. We say it with absolute conviction. We say it with the eyes of someone who saw what she didn't want to see. We say it with the body of someone who felt what she didn't want to feel. And we believe it. Truly.

And then, one day, we hear ourselves. And we fall apart.

I want to tell you what happened with a woman I'll call Marta, because her story might be yours, and because before she understood what I'm going to explain to you in this book, she spent years carrying the guilt for something that was not a character flaw. It was something much older, much deeper, and, curiously, much more human.

Marta grew up with an emotionally absent mother. She wasn't cruel. She didn't hit. She didn't even shout. But she wasn't there. There was an emptiness in her eyes, a distance that no child knows how to name but every child feels. Marta learned early not to ask for much, not to need too much, to sort things out on her own. And she made a promise to herself, so early that she no longer remembers when: "When I'm a mother, I will be present. Always."

And she was. Marta was a devoted, involved, attentive mother. Until the day her oldest daughter entered adolescence and began to pull away, as all teenagers do. And Marta felt the distance as a threat. She reacted by tightening her grip, controlling, demanding presence. And the more she tightened, the more her daughter pulled away. And one day, Marta looked in the mirror and realized: her mother wasn't absent because she wanted to be, either. She was absent because she didn't know how to be any other way. And now Marta, with all her forced presence, was creating the same distance.

The form was different. The wound was the same.

This is the paradox no one explains to us. It isn't enough to want to be different. It isn't enough to promise. It isn't enough to fight against the pattern. Because the fight against the pattern is still a relationship with the pattern. It is still a way of being trapped in it. As long as you define your life in opposition to your mother's ("I will never do that, I will never be like that"), your mother remains at the center of every one of your decisions. You are still dancing with her, only now with your back turned.

And it doesn't only happen in moments of stress. It's in the small gestures. In the way I tidy the kitchen (exactly the way my mother tidied hers). In the way I sigh before talking to my children about something serious (the same sigh my mother gave). In the words I choose when I'm trying to convince them of something. Sometimes the inheritance is so subtle we don't even recognize it as inheritance. We think it's "just how we are." But it's how they were, living through us.

And here is where something begins that might change the way you see yourself.

Because what happened with you (and with Marta, and with so many of us) is not a defect. It is not weakness. It is not a lack of willpower. It is something that systemic psychology calls invisible loyalty. It is a force that operates below consciousness, below promises, below willpower. A force that binds you to your family system in ways you never chose, but that shape your choices every single day.

This book is about those forces. About what you inherited without knowing. About the patterns that move through you without asking permission. About the fears that are not yours but that you feel as though they were. About the guilt you carry without having done anything. About the love that binds you to the very thing you want to leave behind.

This is not a book of easy answers. I am not going to tell you to simply "forgive and move on" or "let go of the past." Those phrases work for pretty posters, but not for real life. What I am going to do is show you the map. Show you why you repeat what you fight against, why you carry what isn't yours, why you love in ways that hurt you.

And when you see the map, something inside you will already be different. Because the first step out of a labyrinth is realizing you are inside one.

Perhaps you're wondering: "But if it isn't weakness, what is it? If it isn't a character flaw, why can't I stop?"

The answer is both simple and unsettling: because it isn't about you. At least, not only about you. What happens in that moment when you open your mouth and your mother's voice comes out is something that reaches far beyond your childhood. It comes from before you. From before your mother. Perhaps from before your grandmother.

There is a reason you repeat what you swore you'd never repeat. And that reason has a name. It is called invisible loyalty. And that is what this book is about.

But before we get there, I want you to do something. I want you to look at the woman you were five minutes ago, before you read these pages, and tell her: "It's not your fault." Say it with the same tenderness you would offer a friend. Say it with the same respect you would offer your daughter. Because that woman, the one who blamed herself, the one who felt shame, the one who thought she was weak, deserves to know the truth: she wasn't failing. She was being human. She was being a daughter. She was belonging, the only way she knew how.

Come with me. Not as a student, but as a companion. I am a daughter too. I am a mother too. I too have heard myself say things I swore I would never say. And that is exactly where my journey of understanding began.

2. What invisible loyalties are

When you think of the word "loyalty," you probably think of something conscious. Being loyal to a friend. Being loyal to your values. Being loyal to a promise you made. Loyalty, as we know it, is a choice. We decide to whom and to what we are loyal.

But there is a kind of loyalty that is not chosen. That is not seen. That operates silently, like an underground river running beneath the house without anyone knowing it is there, until the day the walls begin to crack.

It was a therapist and thinker named Ivan Boszormenyi-Nagy who first named this: invisible loyalties. The idea, when you hear it for the first time, may seem strange. But the more you let it in, the more sense it makes. And the more things in your life begin to fall into place.

The idea is this: we belong to a family system. Not only in the practical sense (we share genes, stories, traditions), but in a deeper sense. The family system has a kind of memory of its own. It has rules that no one wrote but everyone follows. It has debts that no one signed for but so-

meone ends up paying. And every member of that system, whether they want to or not, whether they know it or not, is connected to all the others by threads that cannot be seen but that pull.

Let me give you a simple example before we go deeper.

Imagine a family where the paternal grandfather lost everything in a business deal that went wrong. He lost his house, his dignity, his social standing. The family doesn't talk about it. It is a closed subject, buried, forgotten. A generation passes. The father grows up without knowing the details, but he grows up with an obsession: financial security. He works compulsively. He saves almost obsessively. He is afraid to take risks, even when the opportunities are good. He doesn't know why, but the fear is there. And now the daughter, third generation, an intelligent and capable woman, discovers she has a strange relationship with money. She feels guilt when she spends. She feels fear when things are going well, as if at any moment everything could collapse. She has never experienced a financial loss. But her body reacts as if she already has.

This is an invisible loyalty. The granddaughter is being loyal to a grandfather she never met. She is carrying his fear. She is living his vigilance. Not because anyone asked her to, but because the system has a way of passing forward what was never resolved.

Think about this for a moment. How many of your fears are truly yours? How many of your automatic reactions were born from your own experiences, and how many traveled to you across generations?

I am not saying that everything you feel comes from your ancestors. Of course you have your own experiences, your own wounds, your own story. But beneath your story runs another story. And another. And another. Like layers of ancient soil. And you, without knowing it, are rooted in all of them.

Invisible loyalties show up in many forms. Some are easy to recognize once someone points them out. Others are so subtle that you spend your whole life confusing them with yourself.

One of the most common forms is the repetition of patterns. The woman who says she will never accept a man who drinks, and marries an alcoholic. The mother who says she will never be controlling, and controls everything. It isn't stupidity. It isn't masochism. It is the system repeating itself because something was not seen, not honored, not integrated.

Another form is what we might call "borrowed lives." There are people who live as though they were fulfilling someone else's destiny. The woman who feels she doesn't deserve to be happy, and discovers that her

grandmother lost a child and never allowed herself joy again. The daughter who carries a sadness that is not hers, but that feels like the most real thing in the world. It's as if the system were saying, without words: "Someone has to carry this. Someone has to remember."

And there is also exclusion. When someone is excluded from the family system (the member no one talks about, the child who was rejected, the miscarriage that was never mourned, the first husband who was erased from the story), the system reacts. It does not let anyone be forgotten forever. And very often, a member of a later generation, without knowing, begins to "represent" the excluded one. Lives as they lived. Feels what they felt. Repeats their fate.

I know this may be hard to accept for a rational mind. But the systemic approach is not mystical or esoteric. It is observational. What systemic therapists do is observe patterns. And the patterns are clear: in family after family, generation after generation, what is not resolved in one generation appears in the next. What is silenced speaks louder in the generation that follows. What is excluded insists on returning.

The question, then, is not whether you carry something that isn't yours. The question is: what? And from whom?

You don't need to have all the answers right now. In fact, the journey of discovery is as important as the discovery itself. For now, one thing is enough: allow yourself to consider the possibility. The possibility that not everything you feel was born with you. The possibility that some of your deepest struggles are echoes of struggles that began before you were born.

And if that frightens you, I want to tell you something: knowing this does not make you heavier. It makes you freer. Because when you realize you have been carrying something that isn't yours, you also realize that you can, with care and with respect, give it back. It is not rejecting your family. It is loving them more consciously. It is looking at your ancestors and saying: "I see you. I see what you lived through. And I honor it. But my path is a different one."

Let me give you another example, because invisible loyalties don't only show up in dramatic ways. Sometimes they are so subtle they pass for "personality" or "temperament."

Think of the woman who cannot say no. Who accepts every request, every favor, every demand. Who feels physically incapable of refusing, even when she knows she is exceeding her limits. She may think she is simply "like that," that she was born that way, that she is "too kind." But when we look at the system, we often find a grandmother or great-

grandmother who was punished for saying no. Who lost something important (her marriage, her position, her respect) for having dared to refuse. And the message that traveled through the generations, silently, was: "Saying no is dangerous. Saying no has consequences. Never say no."

The granddaughter doesn't know this. But her body knows. The system knows. And the woman who cannot say no is, in truth, protecting herself from a danger that is not hers. She is being loyal to a grandmother she never met.

Fascinating and frightening, isn't it? But also liberating. Because if it isn't yours, you don't have to carry it forever.

We will see later how this connects to what are called the orders of love and why what you fight against most fiercely is so often what you end up repeating.

But first, I need to show you the silent rules of the system you belong to.

3. The orders of love

There are rules in your family that no one wrote. No one said them out loud. They aren't posted on the kitchen wall or typed into the family WhatsApp group. But they are there. And every time one of these rules is broken, something in the system falls out of balance, and someone, usually without knowing, pays the price.

Bert Hellinger, the German therapist who developed the Systemic Family Constellation approach, called them "orders of love." It is a beautiful name for something profound: the silent laws that govern family systems. When these laws are respected, love flows. When they are broken, love becomes blocked, distorted, painful.

There are three main orders. I will explain each one, not in an academic way, but in the way I understand them: as a woman, as a mother, as someone who also needed to look at her own system to understand what she kept repeating.

The first order: The right to belong.

Everyone belongs. Without exception. Every person who is or was part of your family system has the right to belong. The alcoholic grandfather. The aunt who ran off with another man. The baby who died before being born. Your father's half-brother whom no one mentions. Your grandmother's first husband, the one who was replaced and erased from the photographs.

Everyone belongs.

This does not mean that what they did was good or acceptable. It means that their existence is a fact. They belong to the system because they existed. And when the system tries to exclude someone (no one speaks of them, they pretend they never existed, their place is taken away), something falls apart. It's like pulling a thread from a web: the entire structure shifts.

Have you noticed how in so many families there is "that subject" no one talks about? The person whose name is never spoken? The event that everyone knows happened but that is treated as though it never existed? That silence doesn't protect anyone. In truth, it creates a hole. And someone, usually in a later generation, falls into that hole without understanding why.

The child who feels an inexplicable sadness may be crying for someone the family refused to mourn. The teenager who feels "different," who doesn't fit in, may be occupying the place of someone who was excluded. Not by choice. By loyalty.

Think, for example, of the woman who had a miscarriage before having the children she now raises. If she never stopped to acknowledge that loss, if she tucked the pain away and "moved on" (as society so often tells us to do), that baby who was never born still exists in the system. And it can show up in unexpected ways: the next child who feels an inexplicable loneliness, as though someone is missing. Or the mother who lives with a diffuse sadness that never passes, no matter how well life is going.

It is not about living in permanent grief. It is about acknowledging. Giving a place, even if it is a quiet place in the heart. "You were here. I know you were. And you have your place."

The first order tells us: as long as someone is excluded, the system cannot rest. When everyone is seen, acknowledged, included (even if only in the heart), something settles.

The second order: Each person's place.

Each person in a family system has a place. And that place follows an order. Parents come before children. The first child comes before the second. The first relationship comes before the second. Those who arrived first have precedence.

When this order is respected, there is peace. When it is broken, there is confusion. And the most common violation, the one I see repeated in so many women's stories, is this: the child who takes the place of a parent.

The daughter who becomes "her mother's mother." Who cares, protects, holds everything together. Who at eight years old already knows she mustn't cause trouble, that she has to be strong, that she has to keep it all together. This daughter has left her place. Not because she wanted to, but because the system needed it. Perhaps the mother was depressed. Perhaps the father was absent. Perhaps the grandmother was ill. And the child, out of love (always out of love), moved up. She stopped being a daughter and became a caretaker.

The price is high. Because when you occupy a place that is not yours, you lose your own. You lose the right to be small, to need, to receive. And you carry that pattern into adulthood: the woman who cannot ask for help, who takes care of everyone except herself, who feels the world will collapse if she stops.

This also happens in couples. When a woman places herself in the role of her husband's mother (caring for him, educating him, controlling him as though he were a child), the relationship loses its center. He stops being a partner and becomes dependent. She stops being a companion and becomes a caretaker. And both wonder why the intimacy has disappeared, why they no longer desire each other, why the relationship has become functional but empty.

Very often, this dynamic repeats something from further back. The woman saw her mother care for her father in this way. Or the man saw his father being cared for by his mother as though he were a child. And both, without realizing it, replicate the model. Not because they choose it, but because it is the only one they know.

The second order tells us: when each person is in their place, love can flow in the right direction, from parents to children, from above to below, like a river running to the sea. When someone is out of place, the river overflows, floods, causes damage.

The third order: The balance between giving and receiving.

In a healthy relationship, there is a flow: I give, you receive, you give, I receive. It doesn't have to be exact, it doesn't need to be tallied. But it needs to exist. When one person always gives and the other always re-

ceives, something breaks. When someone systematically sacrifices themselves (the mother who gives everything and accepts nothing in return), the system suffers.

Sacrifice can seem noble. "I do everything for my children." "I don't need anything." "What matters is that they're well." But constant sacrifice creates an invisible debt. The children feel it. And they cannot repay it, because the mother won't let them. And so they carry the guilt of their mother's sacrifice, often without knowing, and repeat the pattern: either they sacrifice themselves too (loyalty), or they reject everything (rebellion). But in both cases, they are not free.

Balance is not selfishness. It is health. When you receive with gratitude, you allow the other person to feel the joy of giving. When you give without expecting excessive return, you allow love to circulate. When you sacrifice in silence, you interrupt the flow.

You are probably recognizing yourself in some of these descriptions. Perhaps in more than one. And perhaps you are feeling something as you read this: a restlessness, an emotion you didn't expect, an urge to cry without quite knowing why. If so, that's fine. It is the system moving. It is something inside you being seen, perhaps for the first time.

These three orders (belonging, place, balance) are like the laws of gravity for family love. We don't see them, but we feel their effects every day. In our relationships, in our choices, in the patterns we repeat without realizing.

And it is precisely those patterns we need to talk about now. About why you repeat what you fight against most.

4. Why we repeat what we fight against

This is the heart of this book. The place where many things may be illuminated. Read slowly. Read with your body, not just your mind. Because what I am about to tell you is not merely information. It is recognition. And recognition, when it reaches the right place, changes something.

I begin with an uncomfortable truth: what you fight against most inside yourself is, very often, what defines you most. Not because you are a hypocrite, but because the fight against something is still a relationship with that something. And as long as you are in relationship with it (even at war), you are bound.

Imagine a woman called Ines. Ines's mother was controlling. She controlled the clothes, the schedules, the friendships, the emotions. "Don't cry." "Don't laugh so loud." "Do as I say." Ines grew up suffocating. And she made the vow so many of us make: "I will never be like that. I will give space. I will give freedom."

And she did. Ines became a mother and did the opposite. No rigid rules, no fixed schedules, no control. "My children will be free." Until one day, her oldest son, at fourteen, began to lose his way. Bad company,

failing grades, risky behavior. And what did Ines do? She tried to control. With all her strength. With the same desperation as her mother. Because when she felt afraid of losing her son, the only resource she knew, the only model she had imprinted in her body, was control.

Notice what happened. Ines did not repeat the pattern because she lacked willpower. She repeated it because she only knew two modes: control (like her mother) or absence of control (as a reaction to her mother). She never learned the third path: presence with freedom, boundaries with love, firmness without suffocation. Because that path is not learned through opposition. It is learned through integration.

And here is the mechanism I need you to understand.

What you reject, you do not integrate.

When you look at your mother (or your father, or any figure in your system) and say "I will never be like that," you are rejecting a part of your inheritance. And by rejecting it, you push that part into the shadow. It doesn't disappear. It stays there, in the dark, beyond your reach, beyond your sight. And it is precisely because it is in the dark that it holds so much power. Because what you cannot see is what moves you.

It's like slamming a door shut and standing with your back against it. You know there is something on the other side. You feel the pressure. You spend energy holding it closed. And at any moment, when you're tired, when you're vulnerable, when life squeezes, the door opens. And what was on the other side floods in.

It is not weakness. It is emotional physics. It is the system seeking balance.

Let me give you more examples, because recognizing yourself is the first step toward freeing yourself.

The woman who swore she would never accept mistreatment.

Sofia watched her mother be humiliated by her father for years. The cutting words at dinner, the punishing silences, the way he diminished her in front of the children. Sofia grew up furious. "I will never accept this. The first man who raises his voice at me, I walk out the door."

And she did. Several times. Sofia did not tolerate aggression. At the first sign, she ended the relationship. But something strange happened: each new partner, so different from her father at first, ended up revealing himself, in one way or another, as controlling, manipulative, or emotionally violent. Sofia began to think that "men are all the same."

But the men were not all the same. What was the same was Sofia's radar. Calibrated since childhood to detect a specific kind of energy, her body recognized it before her mind did. And it confused familiarity with connection. Intensity with love. What felt familiar (the power dynamic, the imbalance, the tension) was what her nervous system recognized as "relationship." Everything that differed from it felt strange, boring, lacking "chemistry."

Sofia was not choosing badly. She was being loyal to the pattern. By repeating the dynamic (even while fighting against it), she was keeping herself connected to the system. She was, without knowing, saying to her mother: "I am with you. I live what you lived. I won't leave you alone in that pain."

That is blind love. The oldest and most painful way of loving.

Blind love.

Bert Hellinger distinguished between blind love and conscious love. Blind love is the love of the child: total, unconditional, unfiltered. The child loves her parents with everything she has. And she will do anything to belong, to be seen, to maintain the bond. Including suffer. Including repeat. Including carry what is not hers.

"I suffer as you suffered" is a sentence no child says out loud, but many live in their bodies. "I repeat your fate to be faithful to you." "I sacrifice myself so that your sacrifice was not in vain."

Is it madness? No. It is love. The kind of love that operates before reason, before choice, before consciousness. It is the love that says: "I would rather be trapped with you than free without you."

And that is why the repetition is not stupidity, nor self-sabotage, nor masochism. It is the most primitive form of belonging.

The man who swore he would never be absent.

Because this does not only happen to women. Miguel grew up with a father who was never home. He worked, traveled, disappeared. The mother raised the children alone, and Miguel felt his father's absence like a hole in his chest. "When I'm a father, I will be present. Always."

And he was. Miguel was at every football match, every parent-teacher meeting, every dinner. Physically, he never missed. But emotionally, he was a ghost. Present but distant. There but not there. Because Miguel never learned how to be emotionally present; he only learned how to be physically present. And Miguel's emotional absence was just as painful for his children as his own father's physical absence had been for him.

The form changed. The wound stayed the same.

The mechanism, in summary.

Let me try to simplify what is happening, because when you see it clearly, everything changes.

First, you live through something painful in your family system. The controlling mother, the absent father, the violence, the sacrifice, the silence. Second, you make an internal vow: "I will never be like that." Third, you build your life in opposition to the pattern. You do the opposite. With all your might. Fourth, the opposite is not freedom. It is the other side of the same coin. You are still defined by the pattern, only in reverse. Fifth, when life squeezes (and life always squeezes), the original pattern returns. Because it is what your body knows. It is your oldest programming. And sixth, you feel shame, guilt, despair. "So I'm the same after all." And the cycle begins again.

This cycle can last a lifetime. It can last generations. Because each generation does the same: sees the pattern, swears to fight it, and ends up repeating it in a different form.

The way out is not to fight harder. The way out is to see more deeply. And seeing means something very specific, which we will explore in the coming chapters: including what was excluded. Looking at what was rejected. Not to agree, not to justify, but to integrate.

Because you can only integrate what you stop fighting. And you only stop fighting when you look it in the face.

The woman who was afraid of happiness.

I want to tell you one more story, because this is perhaps the quietest of all, and for that very reason, the hardest to recognize.

Ana did not repeat a specific behavior. She didn't shout like her mother, didn't control like her father, didn't choose difficult partners. Ana had something more subtle: a deep fear that good things would end. When life was going well, instead of enjoying it, she became anxious. She waited for catastrophe. She sabotaged good relationships, let opportunities slip away, created conflicts where none existed. As if happiness were a trap about to close.

When we looked at her family's story, we found this: Ana's grandmother had lived a happy childhood until the age of twelve, when war reached her village and destroyed everything. Overnight, she lost her home, her

father, her safety. The grandmother was never the same. And the message she passed on (without words, without intention, simply through the way she lived) was: "Happiness is dangerous. When you let your guard down, everything can be taken."

Ana did not know this story. But she lived it. Every day, her body reacted as though catastrophe were just around the corner. Not because Ana was pessimistic or anxious "by nature." But because she was being loyal to a grandmother whose world collapsed when she least expected it.

How many of us live this way? How many of us fear that good things will end, without realizing that this fear may not be ours?

The relationship between opposition and repetition.

There is something I want to make very clear, because it is perhaps the most important idea in this book. And it is counterintuitive, which means your first reaction may be to resist it. But I ask you to let it in.

Opposition is a form of connection. When you build your entire life in reaction to what your parents did, you are not free. You are in mirror mode. Everything you do is determined by what they did, only in reverse. Your mother was rigid, you are permissive. Your father was ab-

sent, you are hypervigilant. Your grandmother never talked about emotions, you never stop talking about them. It looks like freedom, but it is the same prison seen from the other side.

True freedom is not the opposite of the pattern. It is an entirely new place. A place that is defined neither by what your parents did nor by its contrary. A place that is born from integration: I see what happened, I understand why it happened, I am grateful for the life I was given, and I make my choices from within myself, not from a reaction to what came before.

But reaching that place requires something most of us cannot do alone. It requires seeing what lies behind the pattern. It requires feeling what was avoided. It requires including what was excluded. And that is deep work, beyond intellectual understanding.

For now, all I ask of you is this: the next time you hear yourself say "I will never be like...," stop. Not to blame yourself. Not to give up. But to ask yourself: "Who am I running from? And is running really setting me free?"

Because repeating is not failing.

I want you to remember this as you read this book: repetition is not a failure. It is a message. It is your system telling you: "There is something here that needs to be seen. There is someone here who needs to be included. There is a pain here that needs to be honored."

Every time you hear yourself saying what your mother used to say, every time you see yourself reacting the way your father used to react, every time you choose the same kind of relationship you swore you would avoid, the system is speaking to you. Not against you.

The question is: are you listening? And do you know what to do with what you hear?

Before we get to that, we need to explore another layer. Because invisible loyalties don't only show up as patterns of behavior. They also show up as emotions that aren't yours, fears that have no origin, guilt that makes no sense. That is what we will talk about next.

5. What is inherited without words

There are things that pass from generation to generation without anyone saying a single word. You don't need to tell the story for the story to live on in those who come after. Sometimes all it takes is a gesture, a reaction, a fear that appears out of nowhere. Sometimes all it takes is silence.

We grow up believing we are what we have lived. That our fears come from our experiences. That our sadness has an identifiable cause. That our guilt is proportional to what we have done. But what if it isn't? What if you feel a fear that makes no sense? A sadness that has no reason? A guilt that doesn't match anything you have done?

It may be that you are feeling what someone before you could not feel. It may be that you carry in your body what was never spoken in words.

Fears with no apparent origin.

Teresa is afraid of water. Not a rational fear, like the caution of someone who knows the sea has currents. A visceral, bodily, paralyzing fear. She never lived through a traumatic episode with water. She never nearly drowned. No one in her immediate family told her anything that would

justify that fear. Until the day someone mentioned, almost in passing, that her maternal great-grandfather drowned. An accident in a river, when he was young. The family never spoke about it. It was "the sad subject" that was avoided. But the fear remained. It traveled silently, from body to body, until it reached Teresa.

I am not saying that all unexplainable fears are transgenerational inheritances. But I am saying it is worth asking: where does this come from? Is it really mine?

The simple question already opens space. It already creates a small distance between you and the fear. It already allows you to consider the possibility that what you feel may be an echo, not a source.

Guilt for things you did not do.

This is one of the heaviest and most common inheritances. Guilt without a reason. The feeling that you did something wrong, that you owe something to someone, that you don't deserve what you have.

I have known women who felt guilty for being happy. Who sabotaged their successes, who destroyed good relationships, who punished themselves for no apparent reason. And when we looked at the family system, there it was: a grandmother who lost everything in the war and

never allowed herself joy again. A mother who sacrificed herself her entire life and made her children feel that their happiness was built on top of her sacrifice. A brother who died young, and the survivor carried the guilt of being alive.

Survivor's guilt. It is a well-known concept in psychology, but in the systemic approach it takes on another dimension. It is not only the guilt of someone who survived a tragedy. It is the guilt of someone who has more than others had. Who lives better than their parents lived. Who is happier than their mother was. Who has more opportunities than their grandparents dreamed of.

"Who am I to have what they never had?" This question, so often unconscious, lies behind so many patterns of self-sabotage. The woman who is about to achieve something good and, at the last moment, ruins everything. Who finds the right partner and invents a reason to push them away. Who receives a promotion and starts making mistakes. It is not incapacity. It is loyalty. It is the system saying: "You cannot go further than your own."

Patterns of sacrifice.

The woman who gives everything. Who is always available. Who takes care of everyone and won't let herself be cared for. Who says "I don't need anything" with a tired smile while her body cries for help. Do you recognize yourself? Or do you recognize your mother? Or your grandmother?

Sacrifice is one of the most silent and most socially accepted inheritances. Because society celebrates the woman who sacrifices herself. "What a devoted mother." "What a strong woman." "She never thinks of herself." And beneath the celebration, the woman disappears. Little by little, she ceases to exist as a person and becomes a function: mother, caretaker, pillar.

In the systemic view, sacrifice throws the system off balance. Whoever gives without receiving creates a debt that others cannot repay. And that debt generates guilt. And the guilt generates distance. And the distance generates loneliness. And the woman who sacrificed herself ends up alone, wondering where everyone went, without realizing that she was the one who pushed them away by not letting them give.

If your mother sacrificed herself, there is a part of you that feels you must sacrifice yourself too. To be loyal to her. To honor what she gave. To not surpass her. And the cycle continues.

Family secrets.

Every family system has secrets. Some are small, harmless. Others are heavy as stones. The pregnancy before marriage, in a time when that meant shame. The child who was given up for adoption. The uncle who went to prison. The grandmother who had another family. The abuse that was never reported. The mental illness that was called "nerves." The death that was called an "accident" when everyone knew it wasn't.

Secrets exist, in general, to protect. Someone decided it was better not to talk about it. That it was better to forget. That it was better to pretend it never happened. And that decision may even have been the best one possible in that moment, in that context, with the resources that existed.

But the secret doesn't disappear. It stays. It becomes an absent presence, a hole in the family story, a missing piece of the puzzle. And those who come after feel the absence of that piece, even without knowing what is missing.

Have you ever felt that something in your family doesn't fit? A disproportionate reaction to a seemingly simple subject? A tension that appears every time a certain person or era is mentioned? A "don't ask about that" spoken with too much firmness? Usually, that is where the secret lives.

There was a woman who felt an inexplicable unease whenever anyone in the family spoke about her maternal grandmother. She didn't know why. The grandmother was described as a "saintly woman," devoted, kind. But there was something in the tone, in the way everyone rushed to praise her, that didn't fit. As if the praise were armor. As if, by repeating "she was a saint," everyone were protecting something that could not be said. Years later, she discovered that her grandmother had had a child before marriage, given up for adoption, and that it was never spoken of again. The secret itself wasn't bad. But the silence around it had created a shadow zone in the family. And the granddaughter, without knowing what was hidden, felt the shadow in her body.

Important note: If, as you read this, you are recognizing yourself in situations that involve abuse, violence, or deep trauma, I want to remind you that this book offers understanding but does not replace the work of a mental health professional. There are pains that need more than understanding. They need safe, qualified support. If this is your situation, please seek that help. You deserve it.

The grief that was never done.

There are losses that were never mourned. Deaths that happened at the wrong time and that the family could not process. Babies lost before birth whose names were never spoken. Relationships that ended without

goodbye. Countries left behind. Lives that changed overnight without anyone being able to stop and feel the pain.

Grief that is not done does not disappear. It is suspended. And the next generation inherits that suspension. The sadness without a cause. The sense of loss that corresponds to nothing. The emptiness that nothing fills. Sometimes that is what you feel when you look out the window on a Sunday afternoon and a melancholy visits you for no reason. It might be yours. Or it might belong to someone who came before you.

The good news (and there is good news) is that recognition is already a beginning. When you realize that a fear may not be yours, the fear doesn't vanish instantly, but it stops defining you. When you understand that a guilt may be inherited, the guilt doesn't dissolve by magic, but it loses its absolute power over you. When the secret is named (even if only inside you, even if in silence), the system breathes.

The body as archive.

I want to add something that may help you understand how all of this works, so that it doesn't seem vague or mysterious. The body is an archive. It doesn't store only your memories. It stores reactions, responses, patterns that were useful at some point, for someone. The tension in your shoulders that appears whenever there is conflict. The knot in your

stomach when someone raises their voice. The impulse to run when you feel someone is about to abandon you. These are not merely "anxiety" or "nervousness." They are learned responses, often inherited, that became etched into the nervous system as forms of survival.

Your grandmother may have needed to be constantly alert to survive. And that vigilance, that constant tension, passed to your mother in the womb, in breastfeeding, in touch, in the gaze. And from your mother, it passed to you. It is not genetic in the strict sense. It is relational. It is bodily. It is the way fear is transmitted through touch, through tone of voice, through the quality of presence.

When you understand this, you stop judging yourself. You stop thinking you "should be calmer" or that you "shouldn't react like that." Because you realize you are not reacting to the present. You are reacting to something much older. And that understanding, in itself, is already an act of liberation.

Seeing is the first act of freedom. But seeing is not blaming. And about that, we need to speak with great care.

6. Seeing is not blaming

If you have made it this far, it is likely that you are looking at your family history with different eyes. Perhaps you are seeing patterns you hadn't seen. Perhaps you are making connections you hadn't made. Perhaps, for a moment, you felt anger. Anger at your mother, your father, your grandparents. "So it was because of them?" "So they did this to me?"

I want to ask you to stop here. To breathe. And to hear this carefully: seeing the pattern is not blaming the one who brought it. And blaming does not set you free; it binds you even more.

It is tempting, I know. When you realize that your difficulty trusting comes from your mother, that your mother inherited it from her mother, that her mother inherited it from a story of betrayal and abandonment, the first impulse is to point the finger. "If she had dealt with her own issues, I wouldn't be like this." "If they had spoken up, I wouldn't have grown up carrying this."

But think for a moment about what you are doing when you blame. You are placing yourself in the role of judge. You are looking at your parents from above, evaluating them, judging them. And when you do that, you

leave your place as a daughter. And when you leave your place, remember what we discussed about the orders? The system falls out of balance.

Your mother did what she could with what she carried. Just as her mother did. Just as her mother before her. None of them woke up in the morning thinking: "Today I'm going to pass my traumas on to my daughter." All of them, in their own way, loved. All of them, in their own way, tried. And all of them, in their own way, fell short. Because they were human. Because they carried burdens they had not chosen either. Because they too were trapped in loyalties they could not see.

This is not excusing the inexcusable. If there was violence, the violence existed. If there was neglect, the neglect existed. If there was abuse, the abuse existed. Seeing the context is not erasing what happened. But it is adding a layer of understanding that, paradoxically, frees you more than anger does.

Because anger binds you. Anger keeps you in relationship with whoever hurt you. Anger makes you, eternally, the wounded daughter. And as long as you are the wounded daughter, you cannot be the whole woman.

Seeing is different. Seeing is saying: "This happened. It hurt. And I see where it came from. I see that my father was also a frightened boy. I see that my mother was also carrying a weight that wasn't hers. I see that there was love, even when the love showed up in twisted ways."

This is not forced forgiveness. I am not asking you to forgive. Forgiveness, when forced, is its own kind of violence. Forgiveness arrives when it arrives, if it arrives, and there is no deadline for it. What I am asking of you is something different: that you see. Only that. That you look at your system with the eyes of someone who understands that everyone was entangled, everyone was being loyal to something, everyone was doing the best they could inside a system that no one could see clearly.

When you see like this, something shifts. It doesn't change everything. It doesn't change all at once. But it changes enough for the next step to become possible.

I want to be honest with you about something. There is a part of this path that can be painful. When you begin to see your parents as human beings, complete, imperfect, with their own pain, something inside you may feel unmoored. Because the child inside you still wanted perfect parents. Still wanted a mother who always knew what to do. Still wanted a father who never fell short. And letting go of that fantasy (because

it is a fantasy, no matter how real it feels) is a small grief. It is releasing the hope that the past could have been different. It is accepting that it was what it was.

And in that acceptance, paradoxically, freedom is born.

Because as long as you wait for the past to change, you remain trapped in it. As long as you want your mother to be who she wasn't, you keep looking backward. As long as you blame, you remain bound. But when you accept (not with resignation, but with deep understanding), something loosens. And you can, finally, look forward.

And the next step is learning to honor without repeating.

Because there is an enormous difference between looking back with understanding and continuing to live the same patterns. You can love your parents and live differently. You can belong to your family and be free. You can honor those who came before you without carrying the weight that was theirs.

But how? That is the right question. And it is what we will talk about next.

7. Honoring without repeating

We have reached the point where many women ask me the same thing: "All right, Vivianne. I see the pattern. I understand where it comes from. I don't want to blame anyone. But how do I stop repeating it? How do I free myself without betraying my family?"

This question contains within it the very trap. Because it starts from the assumption that being free is betrayal. That living differently is abandonment. That if I don't carry what my mother carried, I am telling her that her suffering didn't matter.

And it is exactly the opposite.

Honoring is not repeating. Honoring is seeing. Honoring is acknowledging what was lived. Honoring is saying, with the heart (not with the mouth, with the heart): "I see what you lived. I see the weight you carried. I see the price you paid. And I thank you, because even with all of that, you gave me life. And now, with respect, I do something different with it."

This is not rejection. It is the greatest act of love you can offer your ancestors. Because when you break the cycle, you are not saying they failed. You are saying their suffering was not in vain. That it served a purpose. That you, because you saw what they could not see, can transform what they could not transform.

Your grandmother, who sacrificed herself an entire life and never allowed herself to want something for herself, would not be offended to know that you allow yourself to be happy. She would be relieved. Because deep down, all her sacrifice was so that someone, one day, would not need to sacrifice.

Your mother, who controlled everything because she was afraid of losing everything, would not feel betrayed to know that you learned to trust. She would feel that her pain produced something good. That it was worth it.

In the systemic approach, there are certain principles that guide this path of honoring without repeating. They are not concrete steps (those belong to deeper, guided, safe work), but they are directions. I will share three of them with you.

The first: Recognizing what is yours and what is not.

Not all the pain you feel belongs to you. Not all the guilt is yours. Not all the fear was born from your experiences. Part of the path to freedom involves distinguishing: "This is mine" from "This belongs to those who came before me." Not to return it with anger, but to return it with respect. Like someone who says: "This belongs to you. I have carried it for a long time, but it is yours. I give it back with love."

The second: Taking your place.

Remember the second order of love? Each person has their place. If you have spent your life being your mother's mother, or your parents' mediator, or the family's savior, there is a quiet invitation to return to your place. To the place of the daughter. To the place of the one who receives before giving. To the place of the one who can be small, vulnerable, imperfect, without the world collapsing.

Taking your place is not selfishness. It is order. And when you are in your place, curiously, everything around you reorganizes.

The third: Allowing love to flow in the right direction.

From parents to children. From those who came first to those who came after. You receive from your parents (life, at the very least, and perhaps much more). And you give to your children, or to the world, or to life.

The flow moves forward, not backward. When you try to give your parents what they should have received from their own parents, the river is reversed. And a reversed river causes floods.

I know that right now you may be thinking: "Yes, but how do I actually do this? How do I give back what isn't mine? How do I take my place when I've spent my whole life outside of it?"

These are the right questions. And I want to be honest with you: it is not something you do with a list of instructions. It is not a five-step exercise. It is not something you solve with positive affirmations in the mirror, no matter how well-intentioned they may be.

The difference between understanding a map and walking the territory is enormous. The map shows you where you are and where you can go. But the path itself needs to be walked with your feet on the ground, one step at a time. It needs a safe space. It needs guidance. It needs someone who already knows the terrain and can walk with you without pushing you, but without leaving you alone.

Because there are inner movements that are not made with the mind. They are made with the body. They are made with the soul (if you will allow me the word). They are made in that space between what you know and what you feel, where truth does not always fit into words.

And there are paths that need company.

8. The crossing

You have reached the end of this book, but not the end of the journey. In fact, if this book did what I hoped it would, the journey is only beginning.

Now you see. Perhaps you don't see everything, but you see enough. You see that there are patterns. You see that there are loyalties. You see that you carry things that are not yours. You see that repetition is not a failure but a message. You see that your parents were also children once. You see that your family is a system, and that the system has its laws.

And seeing is immense. Truly. There are people who go through their whole lives without seeing. Without understanding why they do what they do, why they choose what they choose, why they suffer what they suffer. You now have something you didn't have before: awareness. And awareness, on its own, already changes something.

But (and I say this with all tenderness, because I know it is not what a part of you wants to hear) seeing is not enough to transform. You can see the pattern and continue repeating it. You can understand the loyalty

and remain bound to it. You can know the guilt is not yours and continue to feel it.

Because the pattern does not live in the mind. It lives in the body. It lives in your automatic reactions, in your impulses, in your nighttime fears, in the way your stomach tightens when someone raises their voice. And to reach the body, more than understanding is needed. Experience is needed. A safe space is needed where you can feel what you avoided feeling. Guidance is needed so that what was excluded can be included without you falling apart. Someone who knows the path and walks with you is needed.

That is why I created FreeMe.

Not as a course. Not as yet another personal development program full of promises. But as a crossing. A space where women who have seen what you have just seen can take the next step. With guidance. With care. With respect for each person's rhythm.

I am not going to tell you that FreeMe will solve everything. It won't. Because life doesn't work that way, and I refuse to promise what I cannot guarantee. What I can tell you is that it was built with the same respect I put into these pages. Based on the same principles. With the same

conviction that you are not broken; you are entangled. And what is entangled is untangled not with force, but with understanding, with presence, and with the right support.

In FreeMe, you work with the principles we explored in these pages, but in a lived way, not merely a read one. It is there that understanding becomes movement. It is there that the map becomes a path. It is there that what you have seen can, finally, be transformed.

If you feel the time is right, FreeMe is waiting for you at freeme.viviannedossantos.com.

If you don't feel it, that is perfectly fine. Keep this book. Reread it when you need to. Let the ideas settle. Sometimes the seed needs time before it sprouts.

But one thing I ask of you, wherever you are right now: don't blame yourself for what you repeated. Don't blame yourself for what you carried without knowing. Look at yourself with the same compassion I asked you to offer your mother, your grandmother, those who came before you.

Because you too are doing the best you can with what you carry. And now you carry a little more light.

That is already a great deal. That is already the beginning of everything.

With warmth, Vivianne

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